

6.3 Non-Communicable Diseases

Introduction

According to the World Health Organization (WHO), Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs), also referred to as chronic illnesses, are diseases of long duration that are not transmitted directly from one person to another. These conditions arise from a combination of genetic, physiological, environmental, and behavioral factors¹. Considering the rapid increase in NCDs, information on several prevalent non-communicable diseases was collected from all usual residents in Sri Lanka during the Census of Population and Housing - 2024 for the first time in census history. Accordingly, this chapter presents prevalence of some commonly reported NCDs such as diabetes, high cholesterol, high blood pressure, heart disease, kidney disease, thalassemia, cancer, stroke, asthma, and epilepsy.

If an individual reported having one or more of the diseases, the presence of each such disease was reported accordingly. Since individuals who unaware of having NCD may have responded having "no diseases". Therefore, the actual prevalence rates may differ from these reported figures. Furthermore, in the Census of Population and Housing - 2024, information was not collected from the 2,317 persons reported as the "roofless population," that is, individuals living outdoors without a usual place of residence.

Population Reporting Non-Communicable Diseases

The population reporting at least one non-communicable disease is 4,185,749 (19.2%). According to this data analysis, it is revealed that one in every five persons in Sri Lanka population suffers some form of non-communicable disease.

Table 6.3.1 : Number of Persons Reporting and Not Reporting Diseases, 2024

Type	Number	%
Total Population*	21,779,483	100.0
Population reporting at least one non-communicable disease	4,185,749	19.2
Population not reporting the presence of any non-communicable diseases	17,593,734	80.8

*Excluding the roofless population

The majority of the total population, 17,593,734 persons (80.8%), reported not having any of the aforementioned medical conditions.

Prevalence Rates of Non-Communicable Diseases

In the analysis of self-reported non-communicable diseases (NCDs), prevalence rates were calculated for each disease. These rates represent the number of individuals with a particular NCD per one hundred persons in the relevant population.

Table 6.3.2 presents the number and prevalence rates of the population with at least one NCD, categorized by age group and sex. According to the analysis of prevalence rates, clear sex-based differences can be observed. Specifically, it is reported that 21.8 percent of the total female population (2,459,890) and 16.4 percent of the total male population (1,725,859) suffer from at least one NCD. This data confirms that the reporting of non-communicable diseases is higher among females compared to males.

¹ WHO. (2025). *World Health Organization*. Retrieved from Noncommunicable diseases: <https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/noncommunicable-diseases>